

TWIGTHETICS

The Lean Athletic Physique Guide

A practical, science-based manual for getting lean, building muscle, or recomposing without living in the gym.

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How to use this guide

This is an operating system, not a motivation pamphlet. If you are brand new, start with Section 00, follow the first 14 days exactly, then use the deeper sections when you need detail. The formulas get you close. The feedback loop gets you accurate.

This guide is educational, not medical care. If you have medical conditions, a history of disordered eating, are pregnant, or are using medications or performance-enhancing drugs, work with a qualified professional before applying aggressive nutrition changes.

Quick Start: Exactly What To Do First

If you are new, do not try to master the whole guide in one sitting. Use this page to start correctly.

The guide is detailed because the process needs to be clear, but the starting workflow is simple. Pick one goal phase, set calories and protein, choose a routine you can actually complete, standardize steps, and log the same metrics for two weeks. Do not chase perfection. Chase repeatable execution.

Step	What to do	Where to go
1	Choose the goal phase: fat loss, muscle gain, recomp, or maintenance.	Section 01
2	Weigh yourself 7 mornings in a row and take front, side, and rear photos.	Section 02
3	Estimate maintenance calories, then choose the correct starting calorie target.	Sections 03-08
4	Set protein first, then fats and carbs. Calories and protein matter most.	Section 04
5	Pick the training plan that fits your weekly schedule. Do not pick the most advanced plan just because it looks harder.	Section 12A
6	Set a step target and optional cardio starting point.	Section 18
7	Run the plan for 14 days before making normal adjustments.	Section 23A

The first 14 days

Days	Nutrition	Training and activity	Do not do this
1-3	Log everything. Learn your food scale, tracking app, and normal meal structure.	Complete scheduled workouts. Hit your step target within 1000 steps.	Do not cut calories because the scale jumps.
4-7	Repeat meals where possible. Get calories within 50-100 and protein within 10 g.	Write exercises, sets, reps, load, and RIR. Keep technique clean.	Do not swap exercises every workout.
8-14	Keep food, sodium, water, and meal timing reasonably consistent.	Try to add reps where form allows. Keep steps consistent.	Do not adjust unless weight is crashing, hunger is extreme, or performance drops hard.

Minimum effective setup

If you feel overwhelmed, do this: lift 3 days per week, walk 8000 steps daily, hit calories and protein, weigh daily, take photos every 2-4 weeks, and review after 14 days. That alone will move most beginners.

Your first grocery list

- Lean proteins: chicken breast, turkey, lean beef, white fish, egg whites, Greek yogurt, whey.
- Carbs: rice, potatoes, oats, fruit, high-fiber wraps, beans if digestion is good.
- Volume foods: berries, lettuce, broccoli, cauliflower, zucchini, cucumber, mushrooms, carrots.
- Fats: whole eggs, avocado, olive oil, nuts, salmon. Measure these because calories add up fast.
- Convenience controls: low-calorie sauces, salsa, mustard, diet soda, zero-calorie sweetener, pre-portioned snacks if needed.

Your first training week

Day	Action
Monday	Lift Day A from the 3-day full body plan. Log every set, rep, load, and RIR.
Tuesday	Walk to your step target. No random extra workout needed.
Wednesday	Lift Day B. Try to match or beat clean reps from the previous session style.
Thursday	Walk to your step target. Stretch or do easy mobility only if it helps you feel better.
Friday	Lift Day C. Keep technique controlled and stop compounds before form breaks.
Saturday	Steps plus optional easy cardio if your plan calls for it.
Sunday	Plan groceries, prep 2-3 repeatable meals, review weekly average bodyweight.

What a logged workout should look like

Exercise	Example log
Leg press	Set 1: 270 x 10 at 2 RIR. Set 2: 270 x 9 at 2 RIR. Set 3: 270 x 8 at 1 RIR.
Chest press	Set 1: 90 x 12 at 2 RIR. Set 2: 90 x 10 at 1 RIR. Next time, try 11+ on set 2.
Notes	Energy good, knees felt fine, left shoulder felt tight on warm-up but improved.

The Physique Framework

The goal is lean, athletic, healthy, and maintainable. That requires a hierarchy, not random tactics.

The person who wins is usually not the person with the most complicated plan. It is the person who can repeat the right basics long enough for the body to adapt. Science-based physique coaching generally works from the same hierarchy: energy balance first, protein and macros second, food quality and fiber third, nutrient timing fourth, supplements last. Training follows a similar hierarchy: enough hard sets, good exercise selection, progressive overload, recovery, and consistency.

Lyle McDonald popularized a very practical view of dieting: adherence matters, deficits must be matched to the person, leaner people need more caution, and diet breaks or refeeds can be useful tools when dieting gets long. 3DMJ and Eric Helms are known for placing the same ideas into a clear pyramid: calories and adherence at the base, supplements at the top. This guide uses those principles in original Twigthetics language.

The plan should feel tailored because the inputs are yours: your bodyweight, activity, schedule, goal, food preferences, training age, and progress rate. You will calculate a starting point, then learn exactly how to adjust it.

Core rule

Do not change the plan because one day felt hard or one weigh-in looked weird. Adjust only after enough compliant data exists to see a trend.

The guide is split into three systems: nutrition, training, and review. Nutrition controls bodyweight direction. Training controls what the weight change looks like. Review keeps the plan from drifting into guessing.

Choose your current phase

Goal	Best for	Scale target	Main risk
Fat loss	You want to lose fat and reveal shape.	Lose 0.5-1.0% of bodyweight per week.	Cutting too hard and losing training performance.
Muscle gain	You are already reasonably lean and need size.	Gain 0.25-0.5% of bodyweight per week.	Surplus too high, fat gain too fast.
Recomp	Newer lifter, returning lifter, or higher body fat with muscle to build.	Maintain or slowly lose while strength climbs.	Expecting dramatic scale movement every week.
Maintenance	You finished a phase and need to hold the look.	Bodyweight stable within about 1-2%.	Letting habits loosen because there is no deadline.

Measurement And Setup

You cannot adjust what you do not measure. Tracking should be simple enough that you actually keep doing it.

Track bodyweight every morning after using the bathroom and before food or fluid. Use a 7-day average. Daily weight is noisy because sodium, carbohydrates, digestion, stress, sleep, soreness, and menstrual cycle changes can move water up or down fast. The weekly average is the signal.

Take progress photos every 2-4 weeks under the same conditions. Front, side, and rear relaxed photos are enough. Do not rely only on mirror lighting. Also track waist measurement at the navel once per week, training performance, hunger, steps, sleep, and adherence.

Metric	Frequency	How to use it
Scale weight	Daily	Average 7 days. Compare week to week.
Waist	Weekly	Confirms fat loss when the scale is noisy.
Progress photos	Every 2-4 weeks	Shows visual change and muscle retention.
Training log	Every session	Protects muscle during cuts and drives muscle gain.
Steps	Daily	Keeps activity consistent so calories mean something.
Sleep	Daily	Explains hunger, performance, and water retention swings.

Minimum useful tracking

- Nutrition phase: calories, protein, bodyweight average, steps, and training performance.
- Meal-plan phase: exact meals eaten, deviations, bodyweight average, steps, and training performance.
- Training phase: exercises, sets, reps, load, RIR, and notes on pain or fatigue.
- Review phase: compare planned behavior to actual behavior before changing the plan.

Tracking app and food scale setup

- Use an app like MyFitnessPal, Cronometer, MacroFactor, Lose It, or another tracker you will actually use.
- Buy a basic digital food scale. Weigh calorie-dense foods instead of guessing: rice, oats, pasta, oils, nuts, nut butters, avocado, cereal, sauces, and meats.
- Be consistent with raw vs cooked entries. If you weigh cooked rice, use a cooked rice database entry. If you weigh raw chicken, use raw chicken.
- Create saved meals for foods you repeat. This removes friction and reduces mistakes.
- Use verified entries when possible. If an entry looks too good to be true, compare it to the nutrition label.
- Track oils, sauces, drinks, bites, and weekend meals. These are common reasons progress stalls.

How to read a nutrition label

Label item	What to do
Serving size	Check the grams or pieces per serving. If you eat two servings, double the calories and macros.
Calories	This controls the budget. Do not judge a food only by whether it looks healthy.
Protein	Prioritize foods that help you hit the daily protein target without blowing calories.
Carbs and fiber	Higher fiber usually helps fullness. Track total carbs unless your app has a specific verified net-carb system.
Fat	Fat is not bad, but it is calorie dense. Measure oils, nuts, dressings, and avocado.
Hidden calories	Watch coffee creamers, sauces, cooking oils, granola, trail mix, smoothies, and alcohol.

If you do not have a food scale yet

- Use hand portions only as a temporary bridge: palm of lean protein, fist of carbs, thumb of fats, and unlimited low-calorie vegetables.
- Keep meals repetitive until you can weigh food. Repetition makes estimates less wrong.
- Order a scale as soon as possible if fat loss is the goal. Guessing can work for maintenance, but cutting requires tighter control.

Do not confuse compliance with accuracy

If you say you are eating 1800 calories but bodyweight is not moving for three weeks, either expenditure is lower than estimated, intake is higher than recorded, or water is masking change. The solution is not emotion. The solution is a cleaner audit.

TDEE Calculator

Your starting calories are an estimate. The adjustment process turns the estimate into your real number.

There are two practical ways to estimate maintenance calories. Use both, then choose a reasonable starting point. Formula-based estimates are useful, but the body does not know the formula. Your real TDEE is revealed by your weight trend over time.

Method A: Mifflin-St Jeor

Convert bodyweight to kilograms and height to centimeters. Bodyweight kg = bodyweight lb / 2.205. Height cm = inches x 2.54.

Men: BMR = 10 x weight kg + 6.25 x height cm - 5 x age + 5

Women: BMR = 10 x weight kg + 6.25 x height cm - 5 x age - 161

Activity level	Multiplier	Use this if
Sedentary	1.20	Desk job, low steps, little training.
Lightly active	1.35	Training 3-4 days and 5k-8k steps.
Moderately active	1.50-1.60	Training 4-5 days and 8k-12k steps.
Very active	1.70-1.85	Physical job, high steps, frequent training.
Extreme	1.90+	Hard labor plus training. Most people overestimate this.

Method B: bodyweight multiplier

Situation	Calories per lb bodyweight	Notes
Low activity	12-14	Useful for desk workers with low steps.
Average lifting lifestyle	14-16	Most recreational lifters land here.
High activity	16-18	On-feet job, high steps, or lots of sport.
Very lean/high output	18+	Rare. Confirm with actual food logs.

Calibration formula

If weight changes by X lb over Y days, the implied daily energy gap is roughly $X \times 3500 / Y$. Example: losing 2 lb in 14 days implies about a 500 calorie daily deficit. Water can distort short windows, so use 2-4 weeks when possible.

TDEE worksheet

Field	Your number
Bodyweight in lb	
Bodyweight in kg	
Height in inches	
Height in cm	
Age	
BMR from formula	
Activity multiplier	
Estimated TDEE	
Bodyweight multiplier estimate	
Chosen starting maintenance	

Macro Setup

Calories set direction. Protein protects muscle. Fats support health. Carbs fuel training.

Macros should serve the goal, not become a math obsession. For physique results, the big rocks are total calories and protein. Carbs and fats can trade off somewhat based on preference, digestion, and training performance, as long as calories and protein stay controlled.

Protein

- General target: 0.7-1.0 g protein per lb bodyweight per day.
- During a cut: 0.8-1.1 g per lb is a strong default, with leaner people and more aggressive deficits using the higher end.
- During a lean gain: 0.7-0.9 g per lb is usually enough, but higher is fine if appetite and digestion are good.
- Meal distribution: 3-5 protein feedings per day is practical. Each meal should have a real protein anchor.

Fat

- Default floor: 0.25-0.35 g fat per lb bodyweight.
- Alternative: 20-30% of total calories.
- Do not drive fats extremely low for long periods just to keep carbs high.
- Prefer measured fats: eggs, avocado, olive oil, nuts, salmon, lean beef, and dairy. Do not free-pour oils or snack on nuts casually.

Carbs

After calories, protein, and fats are set, carbs fill the remaining calories. Carbs are not mandatory for fat loss, but they usually help training quality, fullness, mood, and adherence. Place more carbs around training when performance matters.

Macro	Calories per gram	Starting rule
Protein	4	0.7-1.1 g/lb depending on phase and leanness.
Carbs	4	Remainder after protein and fat. Adjust based on training and appetite.
Fat	9	0.25-0.45 g/lb or 20-30% of calories.
Alcohol	7	Not a macro target. Limit it because it displaces useful food.

Macro worksheet

Field	Your number
Starting calories	

Field	Your number
Protein grams	
Protein calories	
Fat grams	
Fat calories	
Calories left for carbs	
Carb grams	
Fiber target	
Daily steps target	

Fat Loss Phase

Lose fat at a rate that preserves muscle, training quality, and sanity.

A good cut is not just the biggest deficit you can survive. It is the largest deficit you can execute while still training hard enough to keep muscle and while staying psychologically stable. The leaner you are, the more cautious the deficit should be.

Body fat/context	Weekly loss target	Deficit range
Higher body fat	0.75-1.25% bodyweight/week	20-30% below maintenance can be appropriate.
Moderate body fat	0.5-1.0% bodyweight/week	15-25% below maintenance is a common lane.
Already lean	0.25-0.75% bodyweight/week	10-20% below maintenance is usually smarter.
Very lean/near photoshoot	0.25-0.5% bodyweight/week	Small deficit, high consistency, careful recovery.

Cut setup steps

- Estimate maintenance with the calculator.
- Choose the rate of loss based on current leanness and timeline.
- Set calories by subtracting 10-25% from maintenance.
- Set protein high enough to protect lean mass.
- Set fats at a sane floor.
- Put remaining calories into carbs.
- Set steps and cardio so activity is consistent.
- Run the plan for 14 days before judging it unless something is clearly extreme.

What good fat loss feels like

You should feel some hunger and food awareness. You should not feel wrecked, cold, weak, obsessed, and unable to train. The goal is a controlled deficit, not a punishment phase.

Example cut

A 180 lb male with a 2700 calorie maintenance wants to lose around 0.75% per week. A 20% deficit gives 2160 calories. Protein at 180 g gives 720 calories. Fat at 60 g gives 540 calories. Carbs get the remaining 900 calories, or 225 g. Starting target: 2160 calories, 180P, 225C, 60F.

Muscle Gain Phase

Build muscle with enough surplus to progress, not enough surplus to get sloppy.

Muscle gain requires training progression, sufficient energy, enough protein, and patience. More food does not force more muscle once the body has enough energy to recover and grow. Past that point, the extra gain is mostly fat. The goal is a controlled surplus matched to training age.

Training age	Monthly gain target	Surplus
New lifter	1.0-1.5% bodyweight/month	10-20% above maintenance.
Intermediate	0.5-1.0% bodyweight/month	5-15% above maintenance.
Advanced	0.25-0.5% bodyweight/month	3-8% above maintenance.
Mini gaining after a cut	Start conservative	Maintenance for 1-2 weeks, then small surplus.

Lean gain setup

- Start at maintenance plus 100-300 calories depending on training age and appetite.
- Keep protein around 0.7-0.9 g per lb.
- Keep fats moderate. Do not let high-fat foods crowd out carbs if training output suffers.
- Use carbs to fuel hard sessions and maintain better pumps.
- If bodyweight jumps quickly in week one, do not panic. Some is food volume, water, and glycogen.
- Judge the trend after 2-3 weeks.

The lean-gain mistake

Trying to gain muscle without accepting any scale increase usually leads to spinning wheels. But gaining 2-3 lb per week is not a bulk. It is a food control problem.

Recomposition

Build muscle and lose fat together when the situation supports it.

Recomp is real, but it is not magic. It works best for newer lifters, detrained lifters, people returning after time off, people with higher body fat, or people who were previously under-training and under-protein. Advanced lean lifters can still improve composition, but the scale may barely move.

Person	Calories	Protein	Training target
Newer lifter with fat to lose	Maintenance to 10% deficit	0.8-1.0 g/lb	Strength and skill up weekly.
Returning lifter	Maintenance or small deficit	0.8-1.0 g/lb	Regain previous loads with clean form.
Lean intermediate	Maintenance or tiny surplus	0.7-0.9 g/lb	Slow progression, photos and measurements matter.
High-stress client	Maintenance first	0.8-1.0 g/lb	Consistency before aggressive changes.

Recomp is mostly a training quality phase. Calories are not the only lever. You need progressive lifts, adequate sleep, enough steps, and high protein. If you are losing weight too fast, recomp becomes a cut. If you are gaining too fast, recomp becomes a bulk.

Adjustment Rules

The best plan is not the first number. It is the number plus a review process.

Adjust from averages, not emotion. The minimum review window is usually 14 days. For women, menstrual cycle water shifts may require comparing the same phase of the cycle month to month. Short-term scale noise is normal.

Goal	If trend is too slow	If trend is too fast
Fat loss	After 2 compliant weeks, reduce 100-200 calories or add 2000-3000 steps/day or one cardio session.	Add 100-200 calories or reduce cardio if performance, sleep, or hunger is getting crushed.
Muscle gain	After 2-3 weeks, add 100-150 calories, mostly carbs.	Reduce 100-150 calories if weight gain is mostly waist and no performance benefit.
Recomp	Improve adherence and training before changing calories.	If waist rises quickly, bring calories down slightly.
Maintenance	Use a 1-2% bodyweight range. Adjust only if you drift outside it.	Same rule. Bring calories/activity back to the maintenance lane.

How to calculate a correction

If a 180 lb client wants to lose 0.75% per week, the target is 1.35 lb/week. If the 7-day average falls only 0.4 lb/week for two compliant weeks, the gap is about 0.95 lb/week. That is roughly 3325 calories/week, or 475 calories/day. Do not cut the full 475 instantly. Make a 150-250 calorie adjustment, then review again.

If the plan is not moving, ask four questions before changing calories: Was protein hit? Were calories accurate? Were steps consistent? Were weekends controlled? If any answer is no, fix execution first.

Diet Breaks, Refeeds, And Maintenance Phases

Strategic maintenance can keep long diets more sustainable.

A diet break is a planned period at estimated maintenance calories, usually 7-14 days. It is not a binge. Protein stays high, fats stay controlled, and carbs usually rise. The goal is to reduce diet fatigue, improve training, and practice maintenance.

Tool	Duration	Best use
Refeed day	1-2 days	Short-term carbohydrate increase around hard training. Useful for adherence and performance.
Diet break	7-14 days	Longer dieting phases, high fatigue, leaner clients, or repeated stalls from poor adherence.
Maintenance phase	4+ weeks	After a hard cut, before a lean gain, or when life stress is high.
Free meal	One meal	Optional, but easy to misuse. It should not erase the weekly deficit.

When to use a diet break

- The diet has been consistent for 8-12+ weeks and fatigue is high.
- Training performance is sliding and sleep/hunger are worsening.
- The client is lean enough that pushing harder would risk muscle retention.
- Adherence is breaking because the deficit has been too long.
- A vacation or high-stress period is coming and maintenance is the smarter target.

Appetite Control

Fat loss becomes easier when the diet is built to keep you full.

Appetite is not just willpower. Hunger rises when food volume is low, protein is low, sleep is poor, stress is high, meals are hyper-palatable, liquid calories sneak in, and the deficit is too aggressive. The solution is to engineer the environment.

Lever	What to do	Why it works
Protein	Build each meal around lean protein.	Protein is filling and protects lean mass.
Food volume	Use vegetables, berries, potatoes, soups, salads, egg whites, and fat-free Greek yogurt.	More stomach volume for fewer calories.
Fiber	Aim for 25-40 g/day from fruits, vegetables, legumes, oats, and whole grains.	Improves fullness and digestion.
Meal timing	Save calories for the hardest hunger window if needed.	Adherence beats perfect timing theory.
Sleep	Protect 7-9 hours when possible.	Sleep loss increases hunger and cravings.
Liquid calories	Remove or tightly control them.	They are easy to consume and usually not filling.

High-volume food list

Category	Foods
Fruits	Strawberries, blueberries, blackberries, raspberries, apples, oranges, watermelon.
Vegetables	Broccoli, cauliflower, carrots, zucchini, cucumber, asparagus, lettuce, spinach, mushrooms, peppers.
Protein-volume foods	Egg whites, fat-free Greek yogurt, white fish, shrimp, chicken breast, turkey breast, tuna.
Carb-volume foods	Potatoes, air-popped popcorn, oats, high-fiber wraps, rice cakes, beans in controlled portions.
Low-calorie add-ons	Salsa, mustard, pickles, sugar-free gelatin, zero-calorie sweeteners, diet soda in moderation.

Hunger protocol

If hunger is high, do not add random snacks. First add vegetables, increase meal volume, use leaner protein, improve sleep, split meals differently, and make sure fluids/electrolytes are consistent.

Food Lists And Meal Building

You do not need endless recipes. You need repeatable meals that fit the target.

The easiest diet is usually a small rotation of meals you like, with measured swaps. Use a template: protein anchor, carb source, vegetable/fruit volume, measured fat source, and seasoning. The food can taste good without turning into untracked calories.

Protein anchors	Typical serving idea
Chicken breast	5-8 oz cooked.
Turkey breast or lean deli turkey	5-8 oz cooked or weighed by label.
White fish, cod, tilapia	6-9 oz cooked.
Shrimp	6-10 oz cooked.
90/10 or 96/4 beef	4-6 oz cooked.
Egg whites plus whole eggs	200-300 g egg whites plus 1-2 whole eggs.
Fat-free Greek yogurt	200-300 g.
Whey isolate	1-2 scoops when food protein is inconvenient.
Carbs	Best use
Rice	Easy to digest, good around training. Measure cooked weight consistently.
Potatoes	Very filling for the calories. Strong cut food.
Oats	Good breakfast carb with fiber.
Fruit	Great appetite-control carb. Berries are especially calorie efficient.
High-fiber tortillas	Useful for wraps if calories match the label.
Beans/lentils	High fiber, filling, but can be digestive-heavy for some people.
Fat sources	Control rule
Avocado	Weigh it. Do not eyeball.
Nuts	Pre-portion 10-25 g. Never eat from the bag.
Olive oil	Measure with grams or teaspoons.
Whole eggs	Count them as protein plus fat.
Salmon	Great food, but not interchangeable with white fish calorie-for-calorie.

Sample Meal Templates

Use these to build days that hit calories and protein without needing chef-level effort.

Cut day template

Meal	Template
Breakfast	Egg whites plus 1-2 whole eggs, fruit or oats, coffee with low-calorie milk.
Lunch	Chicken or fish, potatoes or rice, large vegetable serving, measured avocado or olive oil.
Pre/post training	Whey isolate plus fruit or rice cakes if needed.
Dinner	Lean protein, huge salad or vegetables, controlled carb, measured fat.
Hunger snack	Fat-free Greek yogurt with berries and Splenda, or egg whites with vegetables.

Lean gain template

Meal	Template
Breakfast	Greek yogurt or eggs, oats, fruit, and a measured fat source.
Lunch	Chicken, rice, vegetables, avocado or olive oil.
Pre training	Carb-focused meal: rice, potatoes, oats, fruit, or cereal if it fits.
Dinner	Lean beef/salmon/chicken, potatoes or rice, vegetables.
Extra calories	Add carbs first if training performance needs help; add fats if appetite is low.

Meal-plan rules

- If you use a meal plan, execute the meal plan. Do not turn every food into an open-ended option list.
- If you need a swap, swap like-for-like: lean protein for lean protein, carb for carb, fat for fat.
- Do not add oils, sauces, nuts, bites, and drinks without accounting for them.
- If hunger is high, increase low-calorie vegetables and lean protein volume before changing the calorie target.

Choose Your Training Plan

The right routine is the one you can recover from, repeat, and progress.

Do not choose training days based on ego. Choose based on your schedule, recovery, training age, and consistency. A beginner who completes three focused sessions every week beats an advanced split that gets skipped.

Your situation	Use this plan	Why
Brand new or inconsistent	3-day full body	More practice, easier recovery, fewer missed sessions.
Busy but reliable	3-day full body or 4-day upper/lower	High return without needing the gym every day.
Intermediate, can train 4 days	4-day upper/lower	Best default balance of frequency, volume, and recovery.
Enjoys gym, recovers well, 5 days available	5-day physique split	More specialization without marathon workouts.
Cutting hard or sleep is poor	Use fewer days or fewer sets	The deficit reduces recovery, so volume must be recoverable.
Main goal is glutes/legs	4-day lower-emphasis setup	Two lower exposures per week while still training upper body.
Minimal equipment	Home gym section	Progress with stable patterns instead of forcing unsuitable exercises.

Beginner workout rules

- Run the same exercises for at least 6-8 weeks unless they cause pain or clearly do not fit your body.
- Start with the low end of the listed sets. Add effort and reps before adding lots of extra volume.
- Most working sets should end with 1-3 reps in reserve. You should work hard, but your form should still look like the same exercise.
- If you miss a workout, do the next scheduled workout. Do not cram two full sessions into one day to make up for it.
- If you have pain, swap the movement pattern instead of forcing it. Pain is not proof of discipline.

Routine selection rule

If you are not sure, choose the 3-day full body plan for 8 weeks. Once attendance, logging, and progression are stable, move to 4 days if you want more volume.

Training Principles

Nutrition changes bodyweight. Training determines whether the final look is athletic or just smaller.

Hypertrophy training is about creating enough high-quality tension, close enough to failure, often enough to progress. You do not need to annihilate yourself. You need hard sets you can recover from, stable exercise selection, and progression across weeks.

Variable	Effective range	Practical default
Weekly hard sets	6-20 per muscle/week	Start around 8-12 and add only if recovery and progression are good.
Frequency	1-3 exposures/week	Most muscles do well with 2 exposures per week.
Rep range	5-30 reps	Use 5-10 for big compounds, 8-15 for secondary, 12-30 for isolation.
Effort	0-4 RIR	Most sets 1-3 RIR. Isolation can go closer to failure.
Rest	1-3 minutes	Rest long enough that performance is not limited by breathing.
Progression	Load, reps, sets, execution	Add reps first, then load when the top of the range is owned.

RIR guide

RIR	Meaning	Use
4+	Many reps left.	Warm-ups, technique work, low fatigue weeks.
3	Hard but clearly safe.	Early block compounds.
2	Strong working set.	Default for most compounds.
1	Very hard, one clean rep left.	Later block compounds and stable machines.
0	No reps left with clean form.	Mostly isolation or safe machine work.

Training quality rule

A hard set with stable technique beats three sloppy sets performed because a spreadsheet demanded more volume.

Exercise Selection

Pick movements that fit your body and let you progress without joint noise.

The best exercise is not the one that looks hardest online. It is the one that loads the target muscle well, feels stable, lets you train close to failure safely, and can be progressed for months. If an exercise creates joint pain but little target-muscle stimulus, replace it.

Muscle	Main movements	Isolation/support
Chest	Machine press, DB press, smith incline, barbell bench.	Cable fly, pec deck, push-up variations.
Back	Pulldown, pull-up, chest-supported row, cable row.	Straight-arm pulldown, rear-delt fly.
Quads	Squat, hack squat, leg press, smith squat.	Leg extension, split squat.
Hamstrings	Romanian deadlift, stiff-leg deadlift.	Seated/lying leg curl.
Glutes	Hip thrust, RDL, split squat, leg press.	Cable kickback, abduction machine.
Delts	Machine/DB press.	Cable lateral raise, rear-delt machine.
Arms	Pressdowns, extensions, curls.	Cables and machines are usually joint-friendly.
Abs	Cable crunch, ab machine, hanging/lying leg raise.	Loaded work beats endless random crunches.

Progression methods

- Double progression: pick a rep range, add reps until all sets reach the top, then add load.
- Load progression: add small load jumps when technique and reps are stable.
- Volume progression: add one set to a muscle only when recovery and performance justify it.
- Execution progression: improve range of motion, control, pause, and target-muscle connection before adding weight.

SECTION 15

Sample Routine: 3-Day Full Body

Best for beginners, busy people, and anyone who needs maximum return from minimum gym days.

Day A	Sets x reps	Notes
Squat or leg press	3 x 6-10	Stop 1-2 RIR.
Machine chest press	3 x 8-12	Controlled eccentric.
Lat pulldown	3 x 8-12	Full stretch and drive elbows down.
RDL	2 x 8-10	Hamstring tension, neutral spine.
Cable lateral raise	2 x 12-20	No swinging.
Cable crunch	2 x 10-15	Progress load over time.

Day B	Sets x reps	Notes
Hip thrust or split squat	3 x 8-12	Choose based on goal and joints.
Incline DB or smith press	3 x 8-12	Upper chest bias.
Chest-supported row	3 x 8-12	Do not turn it into lower back work.
Leg curl	2 x 10-15	Hard squeeze.
Pressdown	2 x 10-15	Elbows stable.
Curl	2 x 10-15	Full range.

Day C	Sets x reps	Notes
Hack squat or smith squat	3 x 6-10	Progress carefully.
Flat press variation	3 x 8-12	Stable setup.
Pulldown or assisted pull-up	3 x 8-12	Lat focus.
Leg extension	2 x 12-15	Quad pump.
Rear-delt machine	2 x 15-20	Clean reps.
Hanging/lying leg raise	2 x 10-15	Posterior pelvic tilt.

Progression: train Monday, Wednesday, Friday or any schedule with a rest day between sessions. Add reps inside the assigned ranges. When every set reaches the top of the range with clean form, add load.

Sample Routine: 4-Day Upper/Lower

The best default for many lifters who want muscle without living in the gym.

Day	Focus	Workout
Upper 1	Strength-biased	Press 3 x 6-10, row 3 x 6-10, incline press 2 x 8-12, pulldown 2 x 8-12, lateral raise 3 x 12-20, arms 2 x 10-15 each.
Lower 1	Quad-biased	Squat/leg press 3 x 6-10, RDL 3 x 8-10, leg extension 2 x 12-15, leg curl 2 x 10-15, calves 3 x 10-15, abs 2-3 sets.
Upper 2	Hypertrophy-biased	Incline press 3 x 8-12, pulldown 3 x 8-12, machine press 2 x 10-12, cable row 2 x 10-12, fly 2 x 12-15, lateral/rear delts, arms.
Lower 2	Posterior/glute	Deadlift/RDL 3 x 6-10, split squat 3 x 8-12, leg curl 3 x 10-15, hip thrust 2 x 8-12, calves 3 x 10-15, abs 2-3 sets.

Schedule: Monday upper, Tuesday lower, Thursday upper, Friday lower works well. If soreness is high, reduce volume before changing exercises.

Sample Routine: 5-Day Physique Split

For people who enjoy the gym and recover well, but still want sessions that are focused.

Day	Body parts	Main work
1	Chest + shoulders	Incline press, flat press, fly, shoulder press, lateral raise.
2	Back + arms	Pulldown, cable row, chest-supported row, pressdown, curl, hammer curl.
3	Legs	Hack squat/leg press, RDL, leg curl, leg extension, calves.
4	Chest + back	Machine chest press, neutral pulldown, incline press, single-arm row, fly, abs.
5	Shoulders + arms	Shoulder press, lateral raise, rear delts, triceps, biceps, abs.

This split works when recovery, sleep, and nutrition are stable. It is not automatically better than 3-4 days. It just distributes volume into shorter, more specialized sessions.

Abs twice weekly

- Use cable crunches and either ab machine crunches or hanging/lying leg raises.
- Do 2-4 rounds of 10-15 reps per exercise.
- Progress the load or reps the same way you progress other muscles.
- Do abs on days you are already in the gym, not as random homework you will skip.

Cardio, Steps, And Conditioning

Cardio should support the physique goal, not replace the diet or wreck lifting.

Steps are the most underrated fat-loss tool because they are recoverable, measurable, and easy to standardize. Cardio is useful for heart health, appetite management, and energy expenditure, but it should be added deliberately.

Goal	Steps	Cardio starting point
Fat loss	8k-12k/day	2-4 x 20-35 min LISS per week.
Lean gain	7k-10k/day	1-3 easy sessions for health and appetite.
Recomp	8k-10k/day	2-3 moderate sessions if recovery is fine.
Maintenance	8k-12k/day	Use what keeps health and bodyweight stable.

LISS vs HIIT

- LISS: incline walking, bike, stair machine, easy jog. Easier to recover from and better for most cuts.
- HIIT: short hard intervals. Time efficient, but can interfere with leg recovery and hunger if overused.
- If leg training is suffering, pull back cardio intensity before pulling back lifting quality.
- Do not use cardio to pay for uncontrolled eating. Fix the food structure first.

Recovery And Lifestyle

Recovery is not soft. It determines how much training you can productively adapt to.

A program only works if you can recover from it. Sleep, stress, steps, nutrition, hydration, and soreness all affect performance. When recovery drops, the answer is not always more discipline. Sometimes the plan needs less volume, better sleep, or a smaller deficit.

Signal	What it may mean	Action
Performance falling across multiple lifts	Too much fatigue, too little food, poor sleep.	Review sleep, deficit size, volume, and deload timing.
High hunger plus poor sleep	Stress and sleep loss driving appetite.	Protect sleep window, increase food volume, reduce late caffeine.
Joint pain	Exercise mismatch or too much load/volume.	Swap movement, reduce range only if needed, improve warm-ups.
Persistent soreness	Volume may exceed recovery.	Reduce sets temporarily and rebuild.
No pump, flat look, fast weight drop	Deficit may be too aggressive or carbs/sodium inconsistent.	Review trend and training logs before changing.

Deloads

A deload is a planned reduction in fatigue. Every 4-8 weeks is common, but it should be based on performance and fatigue. Reduce sets by 30-50%, keep technique sharp, and avoid testing maxes. A good deload leaves you hungry to train again.

Supplements

Supplements are useful only after the base is handled.

Supplements can help, but they are the top of the pyramid. If calories, protein, training, sleep, and steps are inconsistent, supplements will not save the plan.

Supplement	Dose	Use
Creatine monohydrate	3-5 g daily	Strength, repeated performance, lean mass support. No loading required.
Whey/casein protein	As needed	Convenience tool to hit protein. Food still works.
Caffeine	1-3 mg/kg pre-training	Performance and appetite support. Avoid late use if sleep suffers.
Fish oil	Label-dependent	Useful if fatty fish intake is low. Ask a clinician if on blood thinners.
Vitamin D	Based on labs	Useful when deficient. Test rather than guess if possible.
Electrolytes	As needed	Helpful with sweating, high water intake, low-carb dieting, or cramps.

Supplement rule

If the supplement does not make the plan easier to execute, improve performance, or fix a real deficiency, it probably does not belong in the budget.

Troubleshooting

Most stalls are not mysterious. They are data, adherence, activity, or expectation problems.

Problem	Likely causes	Fix
Scale not moving	Calories inaccurate, weekends high, steps low, water masking loss.	Audit tracking, compare 7-day averages, standardize steps, wait 2 compliant weeks.
Losing too fast	Deficit too large, food too low, activity high.	Add 100-200 calories or reduce cardio if performance suffers.
Always hungry	Low volume foods, poor sleep, low protein, too aggressive deficit.	Increase lean protein/vegetables, adjust meal timing, improve sleep.
No strength progress	Too much volume, not enough effort, bad exercise selection, poor recovery.	Reduce junk volume, track RIR, keep stable exercises, sleep more.
Gaining fat too fast	Surplus too high, low steps, training not progressing.	Reduce 100-200 calories, increase steps, fix training quality.
Binge/restrict cycle	Diet too rigid or too aggressive.	Use a smaller deficit, structured meals, planned flexibility, and professional support if needed.

Weekend control

Many people diet Monday through Friday and erase the deficit on Saturday and Sunday. If you need flexibility, plan it. Bank a small number of calories across the week, keep protein high, and set a hard limit. A flexible diet is still a controlled diet.

12-Week Phase Templates

Pick the phase that matches the goal and run it long enough to learn from it.

12-week cut

Weeks	Nutrition	Training	Review
1-2	Start deficit, high protein, consistent steps.	Technique and baseline loads.	Do not adjust unless extreme.
3-5	Adjust by 100-200 calories if trend requires.	Progress reps or load.	Compare weekly averages.
6	Optional diet break if fatigue is high.	Deload if performance is sliding.	Review photos and waist.
7-10	Second push with controlled deficit.	Stable exercise menu.	Adjust only from trend.
11-12	Finish or transition to maintenance.	Protect performance.	Plan maintenance before rebound.

12-week lean gain

Weeks	Nutrition	Training	Review
1-2	Maintenance to small surplus.	Establish baseline volumes.	Watch digestion and scale jump.
3-6	Add 100-150 calories if weight is flat.	Progress core lifts.	Waist should not jump fast.
7	Deload if needed.	Reduce fatigue.	Assess photos and strength.
8-12	Continue small surplus.	Add volume only where needed.	Keep gain rate controlled.

Personal Calculator Worksheet

Fill this in before starting.

Field	Your number
Goal phase: cut / gain / recomp / maintenance	
Current bodyweight	
Target bodyweight range	
Training days per week	
Average daily steps now	
Step target	
Estimated maintenance calories	
Starting target calories	
Protein target	
Fat target	
Carb target	
Weekly weight-change target	
Review date after 14 days	

Two-week review worksheet

Field	Your number
Week 1 average weight	
Week 2 average weight	
Average weekly change	
Target weekly change	
Calories hit? yes/no	
Protein hit? yes/no	
Steps hit? yes/no	
Training performance trend	
Hunger level 1-10	
Sleep average	
Adjustment decision	

Beginner Decision Tree

Use this when you do not know what to do next.

If this is happening	First check	Do this
I do not know what calories to start with.	Did you calculate maintenance?	Use Sections 03-04. For fat loss, start 15-25% below maintenance. For lean gain, start 100-250 calories above maintenance.
I cannot hit protein.	Are meals built around protein?	Add a protein anchor to every meal: lean meat, fish, eggs/egg whites, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, or whey.
I am hungry at night.	Are calories used too early?	Move more calories later, add vegetables/berries/Greek yogurt, reduce liquid calories, and protect sleep.
The scale jumped overnight.	Was sodium, carbs, soreness, travel, or cycle timing different?	Do nothing from one weigh-in. Compare 7-day averages.
I missed a workout.	Was it one miss or a pattern?	Resume with the next scheduled session. If misses repeat, choose fewer weekly training days.
I am sore all the time.	Is performance also dropping?	Reduce one set per exercise for a week, sleep more, and stop adding failure sets.
I am not losing after two weeks.	Were calories, protein, steps, weekends, and logging accurate?	If yes, reduce 100-200 calories or add 2000-3000 daily steps. If no, fix execution first.
I am losing too fast.	Is performance, mood, or sleep getting worse?	Add 100-200 calories or reduce cardio if recovery is sliding.
I want to eat out.	Can you pre-plan it?	Choose lean protein, vegetables, controlled carb, sauce on side, and skip untracked appetizers/drinks.

The weekly review script

- What was my 7-day average bodyweight this week compared with last week?
- Did I hit calories within a reasonable range at least 6 of 7 days?
- Did I hit protein at least 6 of 7 days?
- Were steps within target most days?
- Did training performance hold, improve, or drop?
- Were weekends and social meals actually tracked?
- If the answer is mostly no, the plan does not need a new trick. Execution needs to get cleaner.

Noob rule

Your job is not to optimize every variable immediately. Your job is to make the plan measurable, repeatable, and boring enough that progress can happen.

Execution Rules

This is the short version to reread when motivation fades.

- Pick one goal phase. Do not cut, bulk, and maintain all in the same week.
- Hit calories and protein before obsessing over perfect carb/fat splits.
- Use weekly averages, not single weigh-ins.
- Train hard enough to create adaptation, not so hard that recovery collapses.
- Keep exercise selection stable long enough to progress.
- Use steps and moderate cardio as controlled tools.
- Use high-volume foods when hunger rises.
- Do not add random snacks because a food is healthy.
- Review adherence before adjusting the plan.
- When a phase ends, maintain before rushing into the next extreme.

The whole system

Calculate a reasonable start, execute it cleanly, collect enough data, adjust conservatively, and repeat. That is the process.

Worked Macro Examples

Use these examples to understand the math before applying it to yourself.

Example 1: cutting

Client: 165 lb female, 5 ft 4 in, 30 years old, lifting 4 days, 8k steps. Estimated maintenance is roughly 2200 calories. She wants steady fat loss without crushing training. Start with a 20% deficit: $2200 \times 0.80 = 1760$ calories. Protein at 150 g = 600 calories. Fat at 50 g = 450 calories. Carbs get the remaining 710 calories: $710 / 4 = 178$ g carbs. Start around 1760 calories, 150P, 175-180C, 50F.

Example 2: lean gaining

Client: 180 lb male, already fairly lean, intermediate lifter. Estimated maintenance is 2700 calories. A conservative surplus is 150 calories, so start around 2850. Protein at 170 g = 680 calories. Fat at 75 g = 675 calories. Carbs get the remaining 1495 calories: $1495 / 4 = 374$ g carbs. Start around 2850 calories, 170P, 370-375C, 75F. If weight does not move after 2-3 weeks, add 100 calories.

Example 3: recomp

Client: 205 lb male, newer lifter, higher body fat, inconsistent protein history. Estimated maintenance is 2900. Start at 2600-2800, protein 190-205 g, fats 70-85 g, carbs as the remainder. The goal is not a dramatic scale crash. The goal is waist down, performance up, photos better, and habits stable.

Scenario	Calories	Protein	Carbs	Fat	Review trigger
Cut example	1760	150 g	175-180 g	50 g	Less than 0.4 lb/week loss after 2 compliant weeks.
Lean gain example	2850	170 g	370-375 g	75 g	No gain after 2-3 weeks or waist jumps too fast.
Recomp example	2600-2800	190-205 g	Remainder	70-85 g	Strength flat and waist not improving after 4 weeks.

Grocery List And Meal Prep

The easier the food environment, the less discipline you need.

Build your grocery list around repeatable anchors. The goal is not to buy every healthy food. The goal is to have the exact foods that make your calorie and protein targets easy.

Section	Buy
Lean proteins	Chicken breast, turkey breast, lean beef, white fish, shrimp, tuna packets, egg whites, whole eggs, fat-free Greek yogurt, whey isolate.
Carbs	Rice, potatoes, oats, berries, apples, oranges, bananas, high-fiber tortillas, rice cakes, beans if digestion is good.
Vegetables	Broccoli, cauliflower, carrots, lettuce, spinach, mushrooms, cucumbers, zucchini, peppers, asparagus, frozen vegetable blends.
Fats	Avocado, olive oil, nuts, salmon, whole eggs, reduced-fat cheese if it fits.
Flavor	Salsa, mustard, hot sauce, low-calorie marinades, seasoning blends, pickles, zero-calorie sweeteners, diet drinks.

Meal prep system

- Cook 2-3 protein sources at once so you are not forced into random takeout.
- Pre-cook a carb source and weigh cooked portions the same way every time.
- Keep vegetables easy: frozen bags, pre-cut salads, microwave steam bags, or air fryer vegetables.
- Pre-portion fats. Nuts, oils, and avocado are healthy but calorie dense.
- Keep one emergency meal ready: protein shake plus fruit, Greek yogurt plus berries, or chicken wrap with a measured tortilla.

Prep rule

The diet should be boring enough to be repeatable and flexible enough to survive real life. If every day requires a new recipe, adherence gets harder.

Dining Out, Travel, And Social Meals

Real life is not an excuse to abandon the plan. It just needs rules.

Eating out can fit, but it requires boundaries. The biggest errors are hidden fats, oversized portions, alcohol, appetizers, desserts, and pretending a restaurant meal has the same calories as your home meal.

Situation	Rule
Restaurant protein	Choose grilled, baked, or lean protein. Ask for sauces and oils on the side.
Carbs	Pick one: rice, potato, bread, pasta, or dessert. Do not collect all of them.
Fats	Avoid stacking oil, cheese, creamy sauce, nuts, avocado, and fried foods in the same meal.
Alcohol	If drinking, set a number before you start and keep protein high earlier in the day.
Travel day	Bring protein powder, bars that fit macros, fruit, tuna/chicken packets, and low-calorie drinks.
Unknown calories	Use a conservative estimate and do not use uncertainty as permission to overeat.

Restaurant ordering templates

- Mexican: chicken fajita bowl, rice measured visually, extra lettuce/salsa, skip queso and chips unless planned.
- Sushi: sashimi or lean rolls, miso soup, controlled rice, avoid fried rolls and mayo sauces.
- Steakhouse: lean steak/chicken/fish, potato or rice, vegetables, sauce on side.
- Fast casual: salad or bowl with double lean protein, one carb, no free-poured dressing.
- Breakfast spot: egg whites/eggs, fruit, potatoes or toast, avoid turning pancakes plus syrup plus bacon into a cut meal.

Sample Menus

These are examples, not magic foods. Swap like-for-like and keep the numbers controlled.

Example 1800 calorie cut day

Meal	Food
Meal 1	250 g fat-free Greek yogurt, 150 g berries, 30 g oats, Splenda.
Meal 2	6 oz cooked chicken breast, 200 g potato, large salad, 15 g light dressing.
Pre/post	1 scoop whey isolate, 1 banana or 2 rice cakes.
Meal 3	5 oz lean beef or white fish, 250-350 g vegetables, 100 g cooked rice, 50 g avocado.
If hungry	Egg whites with vegetables or extra salad vegetables. Do not add nuts/snacks casually.

Example 2400 calorie recomp day

Meal	Food
Meal 1	Egg whites plus whole eggs, oats, berries.
Meal 2	Chicken rice bowl with vegetables and measured avocado.
Training meal	Lean protein plus rice/potatoes or whey plus fruit.
Meal 3	Lean beef/turkey/fish, potatoes, vegetables, Greek yogurt dessert.
Adjustment	Add or remove carbs first based on the weekly trend and training output.

Example 3000 calorie lean gain day

Meal	Food
Meal 1	Greek yogurt, oats, fruit, whey mixed in if needed.
Meal 2	Chicken, rice, vegetables, olive oil or avocado.
Pre training	Rice cakes, cereal, banana, or bagel with lean protein.
Meal 3	Lean beef or salmon, potatoes or rice, vegetables.
Before bed	Casein/Greek yogurt or whole-food protein if protein is short.

Home Gym And Minimal-Equipment Training

You can build a good physique without a perfect gym if progression is organized.

Limited equipment changes exercise selection, not the principles. You still need hard sets, stable movements, enough weekly volume, and progression. When load is limited, use slower eccentrics, pauses, unilateral work, higher reps, shorter rest on isolation, or harder exercise variations.

Pattern	Home options
Press	Push-ups, weighted push-ups, DB press, smith/barbell press, floor press.
Row	Cable row, one-arm DB row, chest-supported DB row, inverted row.
Pulldown/pull-up	Lat pulldown, assisted pull-up, band pulldown, pull-up progression.
Squat	Goblet squat, split squat, smith squat, front squat, heel-elevated squat.
Hinge	RDL, single-leg RDL, hip thrust, good morning if skilled.
Delts	DB lateral raise, cable lateral raise, lean-away lateral, rear-delt raise.
Abs	Cable crunch, weighted crunch, reverse crunch, leg raise.

3-day home routine

Day	Workout
A	Smith or DB press 4 x 6-10, cable row 4 x 8-12, split squat 3 x 8-12, RDL 3 x 8-12, lateral raise 3 x 12-20, cable crunch 3 x 10-15.
B	Smith squat 4 x 6-10, pulldown 4 x 8-12, push-up or incline press 3 x 8-15, leg curl substitute 3 x 10-15, curl 3 x 10-15, pressdown 3 x 10-15.
C	Hip thrust 3 x 8-12, chest-supported row 3 x 8-12, overhead press 3 x 8-12, goblet/smith squat 3 x 10-15, rear delt 3 x 15-20, leg raise 3 x 10-15.

Warm-Ups, Technique, And Deload Details

Good training should be hard, repeatable, and joint-friendly.

Warm-ups should prepare the target tissue and movement pattern without stealing energy from work sets. You do not need a 30-minute ritual. You need enough general movement, ramp-up sets, and joint-specific preparation to perform well.

Step	How
General warm-up	5-8 minutes of easy bike, treadmill, or rower until body temperature rises.
Movement prep	1-2 light sets of the first exercise plus any mobility that directly improves that lift.
Ramp-up sets	Add load gradually before the first working set. Example: empty bar, 50%, 70%, 85%, then work sets.
Work sets	Only count sets that are hard enough and performed with stable technique.
Cool-down	Optional. Easy walking and breathing can help transition out of hard sessions.

Deload options

Deload type	How to run it
Volume deload	Keep exercises, reduce sets by 30-50%, keep loads moderate.
Intensity deload	Keep some sets, reduce load by 10-20%, stop farther from failure.
Exercise deload	Swap painful or beat-up movements for joint-friendly versions temporarily.
Full reset	Use only when fatigue is very high. 3-5 easy sessions, then rebuild.

Female-Specific Tracking Notes

The plan still uses the same principles, but water-weight interpretation needs more context.

The calorie and training principles do not become different because someone is female. But bodyweight interpretation often needs more patience because menstrual cycle changes can alter water retention, hunger, digestion, and performance. This is not a reason to ignore data. It is a reason to compare the right data.

- Compare weekly averages, not single weigh-ins.
- If cycle water retention is predictable, compare the same cycle phase month to month.
- Do not slash calories because of a temporary water spike.
- If hunger and fatigue spike premenstrually, build meals around lean protein, potatoes, vegetables, soups, Greek yogurt, berries, and planned higher-volume foods.
- Training can still progress, but some weeks may need slightly more conservative RIR on big compounds.

Coach-style interpretation

If photos, waist, adherence, and training are moving correctly, a temporary scale spike is not failure. It is often water, digestion, sodium, or cycle-related fluctuation.

Plateau Audit

Do this before changing the plan.

A plateau is not one bad weigh-in. A plateau is a lack of meaningful movement in the trend after enough time with enough compliance. Before changing the plan, run the audit below.

Audit question	Pass standard
Did you weigh daily?	At least 5-7 weigh-ins per week.
Were calories accurate?	Meals weighed or meal plan followed with no untracked extras.
Was protein hit?	Within about 10 g daily.
Were steps consistent?	Within target range most days.
Were weekends controlled?	No untracked meals, alcohol, or grazing that erased the deficit.
Was training logged?	Exercises, sets, reps, loads, and effort recorded.
Was sleep unusually poor?	Flag it before blaming the plan.
Was sodium/carbohydrate intake unusual?	High sodium/high carb can mask fat loss with water.

If the audit fails, fix execution first. If the audit passes for two straight weeks and the trend still misses the target, make a small adjustment: usually 100-200 calories, 2000-3000 steps, or one planned cardio session.

Ending A Phase

The transition matters as much as the push.

Many people get lean and then rebound because they never planned the exit. A cut should end with a maintenance phase, not a blind return to old eating. A gaining phase should end when waist gain outpaces performance, not when motivation disappears.

Ending phase	Next step
After a cut	Raise calories toward maintenance by adding 100-250 calories at a time, mostly carbs, while keeping protein and steps stable.
After a lean gain	Hold maintenance for 2-4 weeks or run a short mini-cut if fat gain is higher than desired.
After recomp	Choose the next priority based on photos, waist, and training progress.
After maintenance	Pick a clear direction. Do not drift.

Maintenance checklist

- Keep protein high.
- Keep steps stable.
- Use the same 7-day average bodyweight review.
- Set a maintenance range, usually 1-2% of bodyweight.
- Practice meals you can repeat without tracking forever.
- If bodyweight exits the range, correct early with small changes.

Source Notes And Further Reading

These are the main evidence-based influences and references behind the guide.

Source	How it informed this guide
Lyle McDonald / BodyRecomposition	Practical dieting hierarchy, flexible dieting, refeeds, diet breaks, protein during dieting, and realistic fat-loss rates. https://bodyrecomposition.com
3DMJ / Muscle and Strength Pyramids	Hierarchy-based physique coaching: adherence, calories, macros, micronutrition, timing, supplements, training volume, intensity, and progression. https://muscleandstrengthpyramids.com
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